

Extended Essay

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Research Question: How does Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni use conflict to explore identity in *The Palace of Illusions*?

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Introduction

The Palace of Illusions by Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni is a revisionist retelling of *The Mahabharata*: An Indian epic written five thousand years ago. *The Mahabharata* is a tale of events leading to the *Kurukshetra war*- a significant event in Hindu mythology- submerged in male perspective where women have consequences only in their relationship to men and other patriarchs. Where other retellings of the epic often present women as either a goddess or a public woman¹, Divakaruni's novel humanizes and recognizes the essential quality of agency in a woman. She narrates *The Mahabharata* from 'Panchali', the female protagonist's point of view. One of the most notable and exceptionally captivating characters, Panchali is frequently constructed as the daughter of King Drupad, wife of the Pandavas and sister of Dhristadyumna but in doing so, Divakaruni reconstitutes the complexity of the character.

The word "identity" is paradoxical in itself as it means both sameness and distinctiveness. The search for identity is birthed in conflict and is seen in the novel in the protagonist's constant quest for significance. Divakaruni displays the growth of Panchali's identity as one who has been nurtured from the conflict surrounding her and its contradictions proliferate when it is applied to women.² Conflict is the fertile soil which prompts the growth of Panchali and other significant characters. Divakaruni displays Panchali's true individuality, and unyielding determination for both justice and vengeance, by employing conflict and identity as her prime tool. Through these characteristics the figure of Panchali has come to be a symbol of empowerment for women.

Ancient epics are regarded with high importance when forming stereotypes, and therefore have a great impact on the perceptions created in society. Vyasa, author of *The Mahabharata* projects a rather patriarchal

¹ Luthra, Rashmi. "Clearing Sacred Ground: Women-Centered Interpretations of the Indian Epics." *Feminist Formations*, vol. 26, no. 2, 2014, pp. 135–61. *JSTOR*, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/43860745>. Accessed 8 Feb. 2023.

² Gardiner, Judith Kegan. "On Female Identity and Writing by Women." *Critical Inquiry*, vol. 8, no. 2, 1981, pp. 347–61. *JSTOR*, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/1343167>. Accessed 25 Nov. 2022.

viewpoint manipulating the presence of female characters in the epic, manifesting the gender divide in society further. In *The Palace of Illusions*, Divakaruni takes it upon herself to question the conservative image painted by Vyasa, introducing an entirely new dimension by revising the lens of the epic. Revisionism as a genre is an important instrument to explicate and reinterpret canonical or hegemonic texts, providing a critical facet, establishing Panchali's identity through conflict.³ The contemporary characterization of Panchali by Divakaruni recognizes deeper complexities and nuances over an overwhelming emphasis on her physical attributes. In contrast with *The Mahabharata*, Divakaruni presents Panchali's childhood as dictated by the prevalent norms and mores of that time, thus, exploring the internal and external conflict and its effect on Panchali's character.

Intrigued by the revisionist writing of an epic mythological figure,⁴ this essay explores Panchali's character growth as showcased by Divakaruni with the help of the complexity in relationships, language techniques and the conflict development. Furthermore, Divakaruni's ability to maneuver language techniques such as internal monologue, imagery and extended metaphors, effectively explores Panchali's quest for wholeness and identity. The significance of these features used by Divakaruni to reveal the character transformation and development of identity of Panchali will be explored in the essay.

³ "Draupadi's Quest for Identity and Selfhood in Divakaruni's novel" *Smart Moves Journal*, <https://ijellh.com/OJS/index.php/OJS/article/view/11327>.

⁴ Nigam, Richa. "5 Female Indian Diaspora Authors Telling Stories of a Mixed Culture." *Media India Group*. 21 July 2022. Web. 25 Nov. 2022.

Restricted Sense of Self

Panchali's early childhood, in King Drupad's palace, upholds if not causes her restricted sense of self. Dhrishtadyumna (her twin brother) and Panchali were a result of weeks of prayer and a fire ceremony, setting them apart from their family members. Panchali was said to be the young princess who would "change the course of history."⁵ The everlasting quality of the Panchali of Divakaruni is that she is disillusioned with the existing milieu and feels the urge to break away from the limitations set in stone by the patriarchal society. Although her rather radical thought process is consistent in the novel, Divakaruni cautiously reveals snippets of Panchali's true identity, starting from her restricted sense of self.

Internal conflict: Panchali

In the early depictions of Panchali's childhood abode, anthropomorphism is employed in order to convey a sense of restraint upon her identity, "When my Father's palace seemed to tighten its grip around me until I couldn't breathe,"⁶ highlights the limitations imposed upon Panchali, obstructing her potential. This quotation becomes a window into Panchali's perspective on patriarchal societal norms and how they stifled her individuality. The internal conflict evident in this depiction is a tension between Panchali's desire for self-actualization and the reality of patriarchal values.

As Panchali engages in introspection regarding her fate, she contemplates on the notion of heroism and assumes fanciful monikers such as "Off-Spring of Vengeance."⁷ However, these musings are promptly corrected by Dhairya Ma, who refers to Panchali as "The girl who wasn't invited." Divakaruni utilizes rhetorical language in the following assertion: "Who knows, perhaps she was more accurate than I," thus highlighting Panchali's skeptical nature regarding her potential in fulfilling her perceived destiny. This theme of uncertainty is further perpetuated by Panchali's rhetorical question, "But did I have the makings of a

⁵ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

⁶ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

⁷ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

heroine- courage, perseverance, an unbending will?"⁸ Her internal self-doubt serves to demonstrate Panchali's internal conflict as regards to her capabilities, a theme that pervades throughout the novel and contributes to her restricted sense of self.

Panchali's internal conflict regarding her potential reaches a turning point when she recognizes the influence her beauty holds over men. After the patriarchal views of the tutor, who claimed "women were the root of all the world's troubles,"⁹ Panchali takes him by surprise with her captivating smile and bow, causing him to lose his balance, highlighting her growing sense of self as she learns to use manipulation as a tactic. Divakaruni employs an extended metaphor in the following statement: "But inside, a current surged through me at the discovery of a power I didn't know I had,"¹⁰ thus emphasizing Panchali's newfound strength and comparing it to an electrical current. This serves as a foreshadowing of her imminent character growth and resolution of her internal conflict of her potential.

Divakaruni foreshadows Panchali's continued character development in the following assertion: "Perhaps Time was the master player. I would be a player too,"¹¹ thus implying that Panchali is set to take a more active role in determining her own fate.

⁸Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

⁹Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

¹⁰Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

¹¹Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

External Conflict: Panchali and Dhai Ma

Divakaruni employs the conflict between Panchali and her caretaker, Dhai Ma, as a narrative device to illustrate the protagonist's internal conflict and character development. This duo's interactions are rich in humor and showcase the patriarchal norms of society, as well as Panchali's own perceptions of herself.

The character of Dhai Ma serves as a representative of the prevalent societal norms of the time. This is demonstrated in a particular instance where Dhai Ma expresses her concerns regarding the impact of Panchali's lessons with her brother on her character. As she states, "The lessons are making you (Panchali) too hard headed and argumentative, too manlike in your speech."¹² The firm diction and declarative syntax used by Divakaruni highlights the entrenched nature of Dhai Ma's views on the role and behavior expected of women in society. Through this, Divakaruni highlights the conflict that Panchali faces in her journey towards self-discovery, as she grapples with societal norms and roles that are being imposed upon her, sometimes by other women, who one can assume would support women empowerment.

¹²Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

External Conflict: Panchali and Dhrishtadyumna

Divakaruni portrays the character of Dhrishtadyumna as a figure of duty and loyalty. Born with the purpose of seeking revenge for his father, he is resolute in fulfilling his destiny. The novel establishes a close bond between Dhrishtadyumna and his sister Panchali in the opening chapter, with Panchali declaring her love for her brother, saying "I'll love you Dhrishtadyumna, until the great Brahman draws the universe back into Himself."¹³ Through the use of allusion and amplification, Divakaruni effectively conveys the tenderness and strong attachment that exists between the two siblings.

However, As the siblings mature, their differing perspectives and priorities become a source of conflict. Dhrishtadyumna's adherence to societal norms, such as when said "Boys are different than girls, when will you accept that?"¹⁴ creating a stark contrast with Panchali's views, reflecting the socially constructed nature of identity and selfhood.

Dhrishtadyumna's growing sense of self, for instance, prompts Panchali to question her own identity and impels her to break free from the confines of societal norms. In describing the moment when Dhrishtadyumna speaks of going to war, Divakaruni uses an extended metaphor, saying "The word moved over me like a finger of ice. Not if but *when*. With what chill acceptance my brother spoke."¹⁵ This comparison of Dhrishtadyumna's words to ice and coldness underscores the growing distance between the siblings which was once so close and bonded from birth. Their birth from the fire contrasted with this metaphor, suggesting the shift in their relationship to the readers. Through this portrayal, Divakaruni highlights how Dhrishtadyumna's development prompts Panchali's, guiding her towards a self-determined and authentic identity

¹³Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

¹⁴Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

¹⁵ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

Navigating Sense of Self

Panchali's development from a yearning, skeptical young princess to a confident, resilient woman who becomes a powerhouse for all Hindu women was not built in a day. The challenges set upon her as time moves forward increase in complexity, Divakaruni takes advantage of the obstacles to develop Panchali's identity from her restricted sense of self to her navigating, rather brittle, identity. The significance of her navigating sense of self is that it bridges the schism between Panchali's reserved identity and her maneuvering one. The external conflict in her husband's relationship with her, symbolizes the many layers of Panchali's quest for a developed identity.

The Swayamvara

The Swayamvara¹⁶ is an event of significant importance in both Panchali's life and *The Mahabharata* epic. King Drupad organizes the event to determine a suitable prince for Panchali through a challenge of archery. Although Krishna, Drupad, and Dhrishtadyumna have their sights set on Arjun, the Pandava brother, many kings from all over India come to participate.¹⁷ In the Swayamvara, When Karna, the only warrior apart from Arjun who can pass the test, steps forward, Dhrishtadyumna stops him as he is not of Kshatriya blood, resulting in a conflict of honor. However, Panchali intervenes and insults Karna, forcing him to step back in humiliation.

In her telling of the story, Divakaruni takes an unconventional approach. She first recounts the patriarchal account of the event, painting Panchali in a negative light, and then provides a detailed description of the event through the use of visual imagery and descriptive language, utilizing similes such as "Like a lion he rose to his feet"¹⁸ and "Karna's eyes flashed like ice in the sunlight"¹⁹. She then presents the event from

¹⁶ A competition in olden times to decide the husband of a princess, all kings and princes attend and take part in the challenge of weaponry or talent.

¹⁷"The Mahabharata." *The Mahabharata, Book 1: Adi Parva Index*. Web. 13 Jan. 2023.

¹⁸ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

¹⁹Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

Panchali's perspective, giving readers insight into her motives by using internal monologue, a range of rhetoric and visual imagery.

Divakaruni introduces the concept of destiny as Panchali recalls Vyasa's words- to hold back her question just before her marriage- but makes a choice, nonetheless. Through her choice, combined with Divakaruni's diction and figurative language, the Swayamvara becomes an instrumental moment in shaping Panchali's identity. In the aftermath of the pivotal event of the Swayamvara, Divakaruni poses the question, "Can actions change our destiny?"²⁰ This implies Panchali's reflection upon the impulsive choices she made.

Through the transformation of Panchali from a timid princess to a confident woman who asserts her autonomy, the Swayamvara marks a significant shift in her self-perception and identity. Divakaruni employs the literary device of a flashback, exemplified in the phrase "But I was young and afraid, and my ill-chosen words quenched that light forever,"²¹ to provide insight into Panchali's evolution and personal growth. This serves to enhance the reader's understanding of her character and the evolution of her identity

External Conflict: Panchali and The Pandavas

The controversial polyandrous relationship with five husbands was looked down upon by many, and put Panchali in a difficult position, skirting being shamed as a prostitute. Her love and fidelity towards her husbands remained unwavering. Her relation with each one of her husbands helped her grow and identify her strengths. Divakaruni is largely dependent on the Pandavas kinship to Panchali as she personifies her navigating identity.

Instances of the relationships and conflict between the Pandavas and Panchali that brought about character development begin from the very day she gets married to them. Divakaruni employs a strong narrative device of foreshadowing to suggest a developing bond between the characters of Panchali and Arjun. She

²⁰ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

²¹ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

makes use of rhetorical questions, such as “How would Arjun have looked? How would he move? Was he good looking as well as brave?”²² to create a sense of intrigue among the readers regarding the nature of the attraction between the two characters. Despite this growing connection, during the wedding of Panchali and the Pandava brothers, Arjun looks upon Panchali with a “bitter downturned”²³ expression, as if he were the one betrayed. However, Panchali refuses to be cowed, lifting her veil and staring directly into Arjun’s eyes. This bold act is a testament to Panchali’s evolving identity, as she demonstrates a fearless disregard for the opinions of those present at the wedding. Through vivid visual imagery and descriptive diction, Divakaruni effectively depicts Panchali’s agency and assertiveness in navigating the conflict, showcasing her growth as a character. The contrast between the relationship between Panchali and Arjun prior to the wedding and after this seminal event serves to highlight the conflict and spur Panchali’s developing identity.

In the novel, just prior to their departure to their kingdom, King Drupad and Bheeshma engage in a meeting. Divakaruni utilizes simile to convey Panchali's emotions during the meeting with the elders, as she observes "they made me feel like a child,"²⁴ which elicits feelings of inadequacy and immaturity in Panchali. This sentiment is contrasted by the actions of the Pandavas, who value Panchali's opinions and incorporate them in their decisions. For instance, as they consult with Maya, the builder of palaces for the gods, Yudishtra and Bheem seeks Panchali's views on the construction of the castle, an unprecedented move considering the societal norms that precluded women from offering their opinions. Panchali, however, rises to the occasion and confidently proposes, "We'll call it, the Palace of Illusions,"²⁵ after mapping out its unique interiors to Maya. This instance, in which Panchali has the final say on the name and ideas behind the construction of the palace, holds great significance in her evolving sense of self and identity. The Pandavas, by including a woman in their decision-making process, encouraged Panchali to express her thoughts and ideas, leading to her flourishing as a person. The marked change in Panchali's approach to conflicts,

²² Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

²³ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

²⁴ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

²⁵ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

characterized by the utilization of her voice and opinions, signals a growth in her identity, facilitated by the Pandavas.

External Conflict: Panchali and Kunti

Kunti and Panchali serve as two powerful female characters in the retelling of the Indian epic, *The Mahabharata*. Kunti, the mother of the Pandavas, initially held the position of the female protagonist until Panchali's marriage to her sons. Panchali, born from fire, replaces Kunti, who perishes in a fire,²⁶ as the central female figure, thus igniting a sense of competition between the two. Through the use of internal monologue and metaphors, Divakaruni explores the conflict and power struggle between these two characters, providing a perspective undiscovered in the traditionally male-dominated epic.

On the first day of Panchali's life in the hut with her new family, the battle between Kunti and Panchali begins. In an internal monologue, Panchali reflects on her struggle of adjusting to her new life, saying, "I wasn't going to give my mother-in-law the satisfaction of thinking she'd reduced me to tears".²⁷ Through the use of this internal monologue, the author reveals Panchali's unwavering determination and the foreshadowing of her perseverance.

The power struggle between Kunti and Panchali continues throughout the novel, with the author employing the use of imagery and descriptive diction to bring about the intensity of the situation. One instance of this is when Panchali is summoned to Kunti's quarters and is advised by Kunti on an incident concerning Duryodhana. Despite being in the wrong, Panchali refuses to succumb to Kunti's control, thus showcasing her developing sense of self. Through the use of rhetoric, the author emphasizes Panchali's character development from a young newlywed tolerating Kunti's harsh words to a queen who has identified her power and asserts herself when necessary. The conclusion of the conversation between the two characters

²⁶Das, Saptorshi. "Vyasa's Draupadi: A Feminist Representation." *International Journal of Gender & Women's Studies (IJGWS)*. Web. 25 Nov. 2022.

²⁷Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

is marked by Panchali's polite bow, indicating the end of the meeting and the final rise of Panchali as a powerful and self-assured character.

Overall, through the use of internal monologue, metaphors, descriptive diction, and rhetoric, Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni brings about the conflict between the two female protagonists, Kunti and Panchali, which triggers character development in *The Palace of Illusions*.

Developed Sense of Self

In the novel, Divakaruni masterfully charts the transformation of Panchali's character from a hesitant and uncertain figure to a self-assured and determined one. Through the utilization of distinctive diction and syntax, the author highlights Panchali's growth as she embarks on her journey of self-discovery. The climax of the novel, *the Kurukshetra war* marks a pivotal moment in Panchali's character development as she becomes more centered in her thoughts as evidenced by the assertion, "The more people dissuaded me, the more determined I became,"²⁸ here, the author employs language that underscores Panchali's newfound strength of character and resolve.

Moreover, following the conclusion of the war, Panchali finds a greater sense of purpose as she sets out to help the widows of the conflict and form a court for women. This acts as a testament to her growth as a person as she uses her battle scars to aid others and bring about change. Divakaruni's decision to continue the narrative beyond the end of the war allows for the full realization of Panchali's character and the true manifestation of her identity. However, it is the *Chir Haran* that ultimately serves as the catalyst for Panchali's transformation and her conflict with Karna that brings about a change in her self-perception. Through her character development, Divakaruni subverts traditional discourses and presents a nuanced and dynamic portrayal of a woman's journey towards self-discovery and empowerment.

²⁸ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

Chir Haran

Divakaruni masterfully portrays the transformation of Panchali's character through the use of vivid imagery, evocative rhetoric, and insightful internal monologue. *The Chir Haran*²⁹ conflict serves as a catalyst for Panchali's growth and development. At the assembly of the Kauravas, Panchali is humiliated in front of a *sabha*³⁰ of nobles and kings when she is stripped of her garment while menstruating as Yudishtra places her as a wager for, he has nothing left to offer. However, this event ultimately leads to Panchali's outraged modesty finding an outlet in her fervent words: "All of you will die in a battle that will be spawned from this day's work."³¹

In her masterful retelling of the event, Divakaruni employs a distinctive narrative technique by first providing a historical account of what has been passed down through countless ballads and retellings, and then contrasting it with Panchali's personal experiences as conveyed through vivid imagery, sophisticated rhetoric, and introspective monologue. Through this, the reader is transported into Panchali's consciousness and given a window into her evolving perceptions during the *Chir Haran*. The utilization of introspective monologue serves to underscore Panchali's transformation from a dependent figure to a self-assured individual. This newfound sense of self is evident in her declaration, "I no longer depended on them (her husbands) so completely in the future."³² The lessons she learns endure throughout her subsequent exile and the course of the war.

Throughout the narrative, Divakaruni employs a shift in tone, contrasting traditional retellings of the Chir Haran event with Panchali's own experiences, immersing the reader in the Sabah and within Panchali's mind. The change in Panchali's character serves as a testament to the power of adversity in shaping one's identity.

²⁹ Literally translates to stripping of one's clothes; was done to Panchali in the sabha when her husbands lost her as a bet to the Kaurava brothers.

³⁰ A gathering of political powers in Hindu olden times

³¹ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

³² Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

External Conflict: Panchali and Karna

In every iteration of *The Mahabharata*, Karna remains a character deeply ensnared by conflict, possessing a fluid identity.³³ However, little attention is paid to the relationship between Karna and Panchali, a clandestine affair that fosters external conflict between the two characters. As Panchali reaches maturity and contemplates the suitors at her *Swayamvara*, she finds herself inexplicably drawn to Karna. Through the use of potent metaphors and rhetorical devices, Divakaruni illustrates the inescapable influence of Karna on Panchali. "But can a sieve block the wind?"³⁴ she writes, comparing her stubborn thoughts of Karna to the wind, while societal pressure and warnings from Dhrishtadyмна and Krishna are like a sieve, unable to contain her true feelings.

In a break from tradition, Divakaruni, explores this thread as Panchali's mind sways repeatedly to Karna, her attraction to him a deep, personal secret. This secret becomes more pronounced during the *Chir Haran*, as she looks on in frustration at Karna's inaction, hoping for his intervention. It is only during the course of the Kurukshetra war that the impact of their relationship on Panchali's identity becomes clear. As Karna and Arjun engage in battle, Panchali watches as Karna succumbs to the curse placed on him, dying with a smile on his face.³⁵

After Karna's death, Panchali realizes the futility of her pursuit of vengeance, expressed through the use of poignant rhetoric and poetic language. "I realized that we were now very close to achieving the vengeance I'd craved- though it gave me no satisfaction,"³⁶ she writes, reflecting a newfound maturity. No longer driven by a desire for revenge, Panchali moves beyond the constraints of human emotions and embarks on a journey of personal growth. The impact of Karna on Panchali is evident in her musings throughout the

³³ Sarkar, Somnath, and Unknown. "Character Sketch of Karna in Mahabharata, Is Karna a Hero or Villain?" *All About English Literature*. 09 July 2021. Web. 16 Jan. 2023.

³⁴ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

³⁵ "The Mahabharata." *The Mahabharata, Book 1: Adi Parva Index*. Web. 13 Jan. 2023.

³⁶ Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

novel. As she awaits death in her final moments, Panchali thinks of Karna, "his eyes filled with a bitterness I'd put there, torn in two by his love for me and his hate."³⁷ Through the use of an evocative, poetic tone, Divakaruni reveals the profound love that Panchali held for Karna, a love that would prompt her to mature beyond the realm of revenge and towards a desire to serve her kingdom. Thus, Divakaruni masterfully brings the character of Panchali to a full circle.

³⁷Divakaruni, Chitra Banerjee. *The Palace of Illusions: A Novel*. New Delhi: Picador India, 2018. Print.

Conclusion

The portrayal of Panchali's character in the multitude of retellings of *The Mahabharata* presents a dichotomy of perspectives, with some recognizing her as a formidable feminist icon and others perceiving her as an obstinate queen responsible for inciting a devastating war. Undeniably, Panchali embodies the essence of gender resistance and has been subjected to countless injustices, including being tarnished with the label of prostitution and unjustly blamed for the war. The true identity of this iconic figure remains a mystery, one that may never be fully comprehended.

Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni's *The Palace of Illusions* represents a remarkable representation of feminism in Hindu mythology. While the typical portrayal of Panchali in epics tends to emphasize her haughty demeanour, Divakaruni's depiction challenges this notion. Nevertheless, it raises the question of the veracity of this portrayal and whether Panchali's actions were motivated by strategy or born out of bitterness and immaturity.

The enigmatic nature of mythology makes discerning the truth difficult, leaving only speculation. The complexity of the concept of identity adds to the mystery surrounding Panchali's character, making comprehension even more challenging. Additionally, it is believed that while Divakaruni portrays Panchali as impulsive or strategic, some of her actions are driven by self-interest which ultimately lead to the greatest war in recorded history. Although, Divakaruni's depiction of Panchali is valid, with some nuances that the reader takes issue with, as in the characterization of Panchali as the one who mocked Duryodhana during his visit to the Palace, Divakaruni's treatment of the epic is far more empowering and redemptive than other revisionist retellings.

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